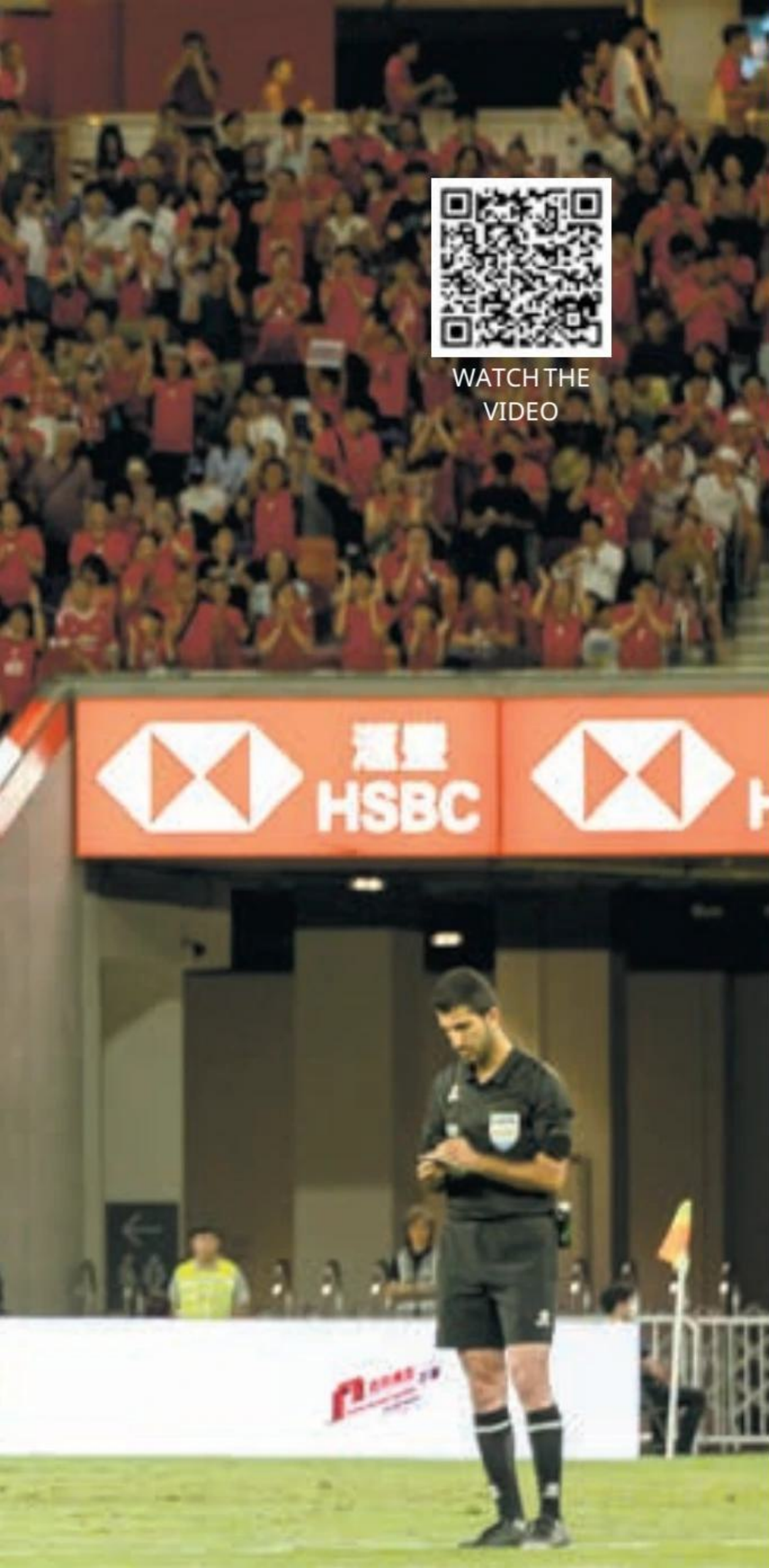




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Dismal: India's latest defeat was its first competitive loss to lower-ranked Hong Kong since 1993. PICS: AIFF MEDIA

international games? Perhaps.

"The main problem for our boys is that we don't play enough international matches. That helps in gauging the speed, technical ability and level of our players against international competitors, especially those from Asia," Subrata adds.

In the past year, Argentina, the best-ranked team and the world champion, played 18 games (graph in next page). India played just 10.

As for Marquez, the damage to the team's morale after the loss was evident, but he defended his boys despite the defeat.

"The dressing room is like a funeral, practically. They know that we are not in a good moment," Marquez told the press after the match.

"In terms of scores, it was difficult for us to score, but the team indeed played with more order than in other games. Unfortunately, we couldn't get any points here." Interestingly, when the two sides last met in 2022, India had opened the scoring in 55 seconds, winning the match 4-0.

Three years later, the tables have turned. This was less a humiliating defeat and more a consequence of systemic failures — poor decision-making and a fractured youth development pipeline.

The age-old striker problem

India's Achilles heel over the past decade has been the absence of an internationally proven striker.

In the last 15 years, successful forwards at the national level like Robin Singh (an I-League and Federation Cup winner with Bengaluru FC in 2014) and Manvir Singh — with eight national trophies — have failed to maintain consistency with the national team.

Robin scored more than one goal annually just once, while Manvir has not scored since November 2023, when India last won a competitive match.

The crisis got so dire that a 40-year-old Sunil Chhetri (**above**) was summoned out of international retirement.

Myopic scouting has compounded the issue — I-League-proven strikers have remained sidelined. Lalrinzuala Lalbiaknia, for example, scored 27 times for Aizawl in the last two seasons while Edmund Lalrindika contributed to 10 goals last season.

Lalrinzuala has yet to play for the national team, while Edmund has played 45 minutes in eight games under Marquez (**right**), with no game time this year so far.

On the other hand, India started Ashique Kuruniyan as a No. 9 — someone who played on the wings under former coach Stimac and primarily as a left wing-back for his club Mohun Bagan Super Giant last season. His pace was effective, but when it mattered most — a chance against the run of play and on goal at the goalkeeper's far post — he shot it wide.



Financial disparity

Indian football has also remained on the short end of the stick from the Centre for its unimpressive performances outside South Asia.

Though it won three trophies at home in 2023, its funding from the Central Government fell from INR 30 crore in 2019 to INR 7.38 crore in 2023.

The same year, FIFA allotted USD 469 million for football development to its member nations, with each country receiving a minimum of USD 2 million.

The funds for India's youth development trickled down to USD 0.43 million — a mere 21.5 per cent.

Meanwhile, the AIFF's budget ballooned by 54 per cent — from a budget of INR 87 crore for 2022-23, to INR 134 crore for the next financial year.

"I think the management, with Mr Chaubey in charge, is going to get even worse. He's got no clue about

